

At this Chicago school, students will help bring solar energy to campus

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Science teacher Jamiu Sokoya, right, with his students Sebastian Rojas, left, and LaShawn Jones at Carver Military Academy in Chicago, Illinois, on April 20, 2026. Sokoya uses a lamp to mimic the sun, to show how electrical power is generated using solar panels. Photo: Antonio Perez/Chicago Tribune/TNS Photo: Antonio Perez/Chicago Tribune/TNS

Two teens huddled around Jamiu Sokoya, their science teacher. Sokoya held a tiny solar panel beneath a lamp. Solar panels convert energy from the sun into electricity. As light glinted off of Sokoya's panel, a miniature fan began whirring.

"This mimics the heat of the sun, and we can use it to generate electricity," Sokoya said.

Sokoya teaches physics and environmental science at Carver Military Academy in Chicago, Illinois. Juniors LaShawn Jones and Sebastian Rojas were the two students watching his demonstration. LaShawn is 16, and Sebastian is 17. The two teens have been selected for Carver's first green jobs

pathway program. They will spend the summer installing regular, full-size solar panels at their high school. They will be paid \$20 an hour for their work.

Alongside four other students, LaShawn and Sebastian will help design and build renewable energy systems on campus. Renewable energy is also known as green energy. It is energy that does not run out when used, the way coal, oil and natural gas do. Sunlight is a major source of renewable energy. So are wind and water.

"It's a great opportunity. Great experience," LaShawn said of his summer job. "I feel like not a lot of opportunities come up like this, around this area. It's a blessing."

Green-Energy Investment

Carver serves about 400 students. It is located in the Riverdale neighborhood on Chicago's Far South Side.

Sokoya has been having students build solar models as a class exercise for years. But he never expected full-scale green infrastructure to arrive at Carver. Infrastructure is everything that makes modern life possible, from roads and bridges to buildings and heating systems. Green infrastructure is infrastructure that is designed to minimize environmental damage. It works in harmony with natural systems.

Sokoya is a member of the Chicago Teachers Union Climate Justice Committee. He has long pushed for sustainable school infrastructure development. Sustainable development is development that avoids harm to the environment. Its goal is to preserve resources for future generations.

"It's a dream come true," Sokoya said of Carver's new green jobs program. "Our students at Carver, they're going to be benefitting. ... They can actually go and get a career in solar panel installation [after they leave school]. That's the exciting part for me."

LaShawn and Sebastian were both eager to apply for the solar panel jobs.

LaShawn hopes to become an HVAC (Heating, Ventilation and Air Conditioning) technician. Sebastian has long been drawn to construction. He enjoys hands-on work and hopes to pursue trade school after graduation.

"It's a big opportunity," he said. "It brings attention, resources and new ideas to our school."

Long Fight For Environmental Rights

Carver opened in 1947, near a heavily industrial zone. Nearby factories have been criticized for adding pollution to the area.

Altgeld Gardens Homes sits just a half mile away. It is a large public housing complex and is often called the birthplace of Chicago's environmental rights movement. One of its residents, Hazel M. Johnson, challenged the city's housing authority to address poor water and air quality.



Image 1. Science teacher Jamiu Sokoya talks with students in his physics class at Carver Military Academy in Chicago on April 20, 2026. Photo: Antonio Perez/Chicago Tribune/TNS

Lauren Bianchi is a green schools organizer. She sees the solar panel installation project as a continuation of Altgeld Gardens' early environmental activism. It is building on the history of "Black-led environmental justice organizing in this part of Chicago," she said.

Making a Safer, Healthier World

LaShawn and Sebastian are eager to apply their math and science skills through the summer.

"Solar power is good for our future because it's clean, it doesn't run out and it helps cut down on pollution," Sebastian said. "It can lower energy costs and create new jobs. ... Using solar energy now helps make the world safer and healthier for the next generation."

Write Prompt

Write a short fictional narrative. Use at least one person from the article.

Quiz

- 1 Read the paragraph from the section “Long Fight For Environmental Rights.”

Altgeld Gardens Homes sits just a half mile away. It is a large public housing complex and is often called the birthplace of Chicago’s environmental rights movement. One of its residents, Hazel M. Johnson, challenged the city’s housing authority to address poor water and air quality.

Which statement summarizes the paragraph?

- (A) Chicago’s environmental rights movement failed to address issues of poor water and air quality at Altgeld Gardens.
- (B) Hazel M. Johnson was originally recruited to join Chicago’s environmental rights movement when she lived at Altgeld Gardens.
- (C) The Altgeld Gardens Homes sits a half-mile away from the Carver Military Academy and was the birthplace of environmental activist Hazel M. Johnson.
- (D) Chicago’s environmental rights movement began when Hazel M. Johnson, an Altgeld Gardens resident, demanded the city address the area’s poor water and air quality.

- 2 Read the section “Making A Safer, Healthier World.” Which sentence from this section supports the conclusion that solar power is good for the economy?

- (A) Jones and Rojas are eager to apply their math and science skills through the summer.
- (B) “Solar power is good for our future because it’s clean, it doesn’t run out and it helps cut down on pollution,” Rojas said.
- (C) “It can lower energy costs and create new jobs.”
- (D) “Using solar energy now helps make the world safer and healthier for the next generation.”

- 3 Read the section “Green-Energy Investment.” Which sentence from the section shows how green infrastructure minimizes environmental damage?

- (A) Sokoya has been having students build solar models as a class exercise for years.
- (B) It works in harmony with natural systems.
- (C) He has long pushed for sustainable school infrastructure development.
- (D) “It brings attention, resources and new ideas to our school.”

- 4 Which sentence from the article supports the main idea that Carver Military Academy students are excited by the school’s new green jobs program?

- (A) Sokoya teaches physics and environmental science at Carver Military Academy in Chicago, Illinois.
- (B) “I feel like not a lot of opportunities come up like this, around this area.”
- (C) “It’s a dream come true,” Sokoya said of Carver’s new green jobs program.
- (D) She sees the solar panel installation project as a continuation of Altgeld Gardens’ early environmental activism.

Answer Key

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